

Of toys and syntaxes

CHANCES ARE THAT YOU'VE COME ACROSS SEVERAL ADS FROM MULTIPLE EDUCATION COMPANIES ABOUT COURSES THAT TEACH KIDS TO CODE.

There's nothing wrong about teaching kids to code but the way these companies have been preying on the insecurities of parents to sell these courses is of concern. Some of these companies don't even have a compelling product and are simply repackaging open-source programming languages such as MIT's Scratch which was designed for kids. Since these software are licensed under GPL, it is perfectly legal to charge money for the same. These companies are simply minting money off of the parents' ignorance. YouTube is now littered with countless video recordings in which we can see educators of the same companies being unable to resolve some of the simplest programming queries that their young students have. The educators have a script, which they follow and there's little value addition happening at any point of the process.

I'm not going to get into whether kids ought to learn how to code. They most certainly should but parents ought to perform a little due diligence before signing their kids up for programming courses. What's the point of signing up for such courses if the kids are going to be taught coding by folks who don't even understand the basic concepts themselves. It's no secret that the vast majority of the engineering graduates in our country are barely eligible for coding jobs and have to be retrained for close to a year at their job before they can start off in any role. That same logic applies here as well. If kids aren't properly introduced to the basic concepts and gradually taught the various programming paradigms, they'll never get it. Who knows, one might end up disenchanting kids and causing them to hate programming. Years down the line, you'll have more people staying away from STEM streams because they had a bad experience with one of these "education" startups during their childhood.

One could also question the end-goal of this exercise. As with every skill, we have more automatons being developed every day to take over mundane human tasks so that humans can be freed-up to pursue more complex workloads or important tasks that

require human supervision. We already have numerous frameworks that allow rapid development and deployment of software. Tasks which required multiple low-tier programmers a couple of weeks to execute are now being dealt with just a few simple commands. Unless you have the passion for coding which can either be innate or developed carefully by an experienced educator, you're probably going to struggle to attain a high-level of proficiency that's required for the jobs of the future. And we even have AI systems such as the recently unveiled OpenAI GPT-3 which can be taught to talk, write and even code like humans. Unless you work on improving your skill, you'll be relegated to being a low-tier programmer who could very well be lining up for a minimum wage programming job in the future. Heck, McDonalds could very well provide you a side order of a freshly developed smartphone app along with your piping hot fries.

Then there's the fact that programming, like all skills, needs ample amounts of practise and newer languages have to be learned as and when they start getting popular. Learning a new language becomes quite simple if you already know the basic concepts of a similar language. Let's say that you ensure your kid a headstart in the 3rd Grade and there's another kid who learns to code as part of his or her curriculum around the 8-9th grade, by the time these two enter the job pool they'll most certainly have to learn a completely different language that's actually in demand 10 years down the line. At that point of time, neither individual can be termed to have an advantage over the other. One was forced to learn coding without developing a passion for it and the other enjoyed a joyous childhood. At the end, both of them are on a level playing field. There is obviously that one-in-a-million chance that the first child figures out a novel business idea, builds an app, attracts the attention of VCs and builds the next Facebook by the time they're 17, only to cash out and retire a billionaire by 20.

Let kids be kids. Introduce the concept of coding and let them figure things out on their own, if they have the passion, that kid could very well end up as the next Zuckerberg but more often than not, they'll end up just like you and I. **d**



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